Tooltips & Popovers

Inclusion Toolkit

What is it for?

Tooltips and popovers give users extra information on demand, but they often fail accessibility by being:

- Mouse-only. They don't appear for keyboard users (focus)
- Silent. Screen readers don't announce the new content
- Hard to close. Users get 'stuck', or the tooltip vanishes too fast

It's important to note that popovers and modals are not the same thing. A modal demands your full attention, while a popover just offers extra information

How to support it

They must work for keyboard, mouse, and screen reader users.

- Simple tooltips (read-only information) should show on hover and focus, stay visible, close with Escape, and use `aria-describedby` to link the trigger to the tooltip so screen readers announce it
- Complex popovers (with buttons or links inside) should trigger on click (not hover), manage keyboard focus, and be easy to close

Useful Links

WAI-ARIA Authoring Practices - Tooltip Pattern